

Radiotherapy for pancreatic cancer

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays to destroy pancreatic cancer cells, while doing as little harm as possible to normal cells.

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What is radiotherapy?

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays to treat cancer. It destroys cancer cells in the area where the radiotherapy is given.

Radiotherapy is not used as often as [surgery](#) or [chemotherapy](#). You may be offered radiotherapy as part of a [cancer research trial](#).

You may have radiotherapy to treat pancreatic cancer that has not spread but cannot be removed by surgery. In this case, you might have it with chemotherapy. This is called chemoradiation. Chemoradiation aims to shrink the cancer and control it for as long as possible. The chemotherapy is usually a drug called [capecitabine](#), which comes as tablets.

Palliative radiotherapy

You may also have radiotherapy to relieve symptoms of cancer. This is called palliative radiotherapy. You will most likely have it to treat pain. It works by shrinking the tumour. This reduces the pressure that is causing pain. If you are having palliative radiotherapy to control the cancer, you will have lower doses than usual. It is also usually a shorter course of treatment and is less likely to cause side effects.

Stereotactic body radiotherapy (SBRT)

You may have a type of radiotherapy called [stereotactic body radiotherapy \(SBRT\)](#). SBRT is a very precise way of giving higher doses of radiation with smaller number of treatments. You will usually have 5 treatments over 1 to 2 weeks.

Having radiotherapy for pancreatic cancer

You will have radiotherapy in the hospital radiotherapy department. How you have the treatment depends on your needs.

Sometimes, for symptom control, a single treatment of palliative radiotherapy is all you need.

Or you may have a course of radiotherapy as a series of short, daily sessions. Each treatment takes 10 to 15 minutes.

You usually have a course of treatment daily, Monday to Friday, with a rest at the weekend. Your doctor will discuss the treatment and possible side effects with you.

Support from Macmillan

Macmillan is also here to support you. If you would like to talk, you can:

- Call the Macmillan Support Line on [0808 808 00 00](tel:0808 808 00 00).
- [Chat to our specialists online](#).
- Visit our [pancreatic cancer forum](#) to talk to people who have been affected by pancreatic cancer, share your experience, and ask an expert your questions.

Treatment sessions

At the beginning of each radiotherapy session, the radiographer will position you carefully on the couch. They will make sure you are comfortable.

During your treatment, you will be alone in the room. But you can talk to the radiographer, who will watch you from the next room.

Radiotherapy is not painful. But you must lie still for a few minutes during treatment.

Side effects of radiotherapy for pancreatic cancer

Radiotherapy for [pancreatic cancer](#) can cause side effects, such as:

- sickness
- loss of appetite
- diarrhoea
- tiredness.

These [side effects](#) are usually mild. They will depend on how much treatment you are having. Having [chemoradiation](#) can make the side effects of treatment worse. Your cancer specialist will be able to advise you what to expect. They will also give you treatments to help with any side effects.

This treatment does not make you radioactive. It is safe for you to be with other people, including children, after your treatment.

About our information

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our pancreatic cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at cancerinformationteam@macmillan.org.uk

European Society for Medical Oncology, Cancer of the pancreas: ESMO clinical Practice Guidelines. Volume 26, Supplement 5, V56-V68, 1 September 2015. Available from: <https://doi.org/10.1093/annonc/mdv295> (accessed May 2021).

National Institute for Health and Care Excellence. Pancreatic cancer in adults: diagnosis and management. NICE guideline (NG85). Published 7 February 2018. Available at: <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/ng85/chapter/Recommendations> (accessed May 2021).

Reviewers



This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer. It has been approved by Chief Medical Editor, [Professor Tim Iveson](#), Consultant Medical Oncologist.

Our cancer information has been awarded the [PIF TICK](#). Created by the Patient Information Forum, this quality mark shows we meet PIF's 10 criteria for trustworthy health information.

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 05 January 2022 | Next review: 05 January 2025

ⓘ This content is currently being reviewed. New information will be coming soon.

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information.](#)

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help